

HAOYU ZHAI

Division of Social Science, New York University Abu Dhabi

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Quantitative social scientist with training in applied econometrics, applied statistics, and quantitative social and policy research methods more broadly. My work is methodological and data-intensive in orientation, with an interdisciplinary outlook; recent research centers on political economy and political finance.

EDUCATION

- 2023 **Ph.D., Political and Social Science at European University Institute, Florence**
Dissertation: "Three Papers in Applied Political Methodology"
- 2020 **M.Res., Political and Social Science at European University Institute, Florence**
- 2019 **M.Phil., Comparative Government at University of Oxford**
Affiliated Graduate Student, Centre for Experimental Social Sciences (CESS)
- 2017 **B.Sc., Politics with Quantitative Research Methods (First Class Honours) at University of Bristol**

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

- 2023–present **New York University Abu Dhabi, Division of Social Science**
Associate Research Scientist (Sep 2026–present); Research Associate (2023–2026)
- Design, implement, and analyze surveys and field experiments examining behavior and policy interventions, including blocking/stratification design and power calculations for a get-out-the-vote field experiment run with international partners.
 - Manage and analyze large-scale datasets, including full-count census microdata, geospatial and climatic data, survey and field-experiment data, and administrative records.
 - Design and implement statistical workflows in R, Python, and GIS for data management, visualization, causal inference, and policy evaluation.
 - Supervise and train undergraduate research assistants in statistical software, data management, and reproducible workflow.
 - Use high-performance computing resources for large-scale data processing.
 - Collaborating with a computational social scientist on the design and technical build of a website and paper-submission system for the RC28 (ISA Research Committee on Social Stratification and Mobility) conference, and providing research support to the Division's Dean.
- 2022–2023 **WZB Berlin Social Science Center**
Visiting Researcher, Institutions and Political Inequality Research Unit
- Contributed to the COVID-19 Model Challenges project, a cross-institutional effort crowdsourcing and aggregating statistical models of the socioeconomic correlates of COVID-19 mortality; built and maintained data/modeling pipelines and contributed to analysis and visualization.
- 2020–2023 **European University Institute**
Research Assistant, Department of Political and Social Sciences
- 2018–2019 **University of Oxford**
Research Assistant, Nuffield College (2019); Research Intern, Kellogg College (2018)
- 2016 **Institute of Economic Affairs, London**
Research Intern

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

- 2020–2021 **Teaching Assistant, Statistics of Causal Inference (graduate elective, joint with the Department of Economics) at European University Institute**
- Ran R computer labs, prepared and maintained problem sets, managed grading and assessment, held office hours.

2018–2019	College Tutor, Political Sociology (undergraduate elective), Worcester College, University of Oxford
	Led weekly small-group tutorials; advised students on essay technique and examination preparation.
2023–present	Research Mentoring, New York University Abu Dhabi
	Supervise and train undergraduate research assistants in statistical computing and reproducible research practice.
2021	Invited Instructional Session, COVID-19 Model Challenges, LSE Data Science Institute, CIVICA Research Hackathon

PUBLICATIONS (PEER-REVIEWED)

2025	S. Weber, N. Stoop, P. van der Windt, and H. Zhai. “A Meta-Analysis of Attitudes Towards Migrants and Displaced Persons.” <i>British Journal of Political Science</i> 55:e168, 1–30. doi.org/10.1017/S0007123425101075
2025	J. Barceló, C. Paik, P. van der Windt, and H. Zhai. “A Global Ranking of Research Productivity of Political Science Departments.” <i>PS: Political Science & Politics</i> 58(3), 574–585. doi.org/10.1017/S1049096524001239
2024	J. Barceló, J. L. Jensen, L. Peisakhin, and H. Zhai. “New Estimates of US Civil War Mortality from Full-Census Records.” <i>Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences</i> 121(48), e2414919121. doi.org/10.1073/pnas.2414919121
2023	J. Lindvall, D. Rueda, and H. Zhai. “When Parties Move to the Middle: The Role of Uncertainty.” <i>British Journal of Political Science</i> 53(4), 1208–1229. doi.org/10.1017/S0007123422000758
2022	S. Garside and H. Zhai. “If Not Now, When? Climate Disaster and the Green Vote Following the 2021 Germany Floods.” <i>Research & Politics</i> 9(4), 137401. doi.org/10.1177/20531680221141523

UNDER REVIEW

C. Paik and H. Zhai. “The Mongol Conquest and Development in Eurasia before the Age of Exploration.” *British Journal of Political Science*, under review.

M. A. Golden, T. Slough, H. Zhai, et al. “The Model Challenges: Gathering, Aggregating, and Evaluating Covid Mortality Models.” *Perspectives on Politics*, under review.

WORK IN PROGRESS

H. Zhai. “Political Deliberation as Network: An Applied Methodological Note.”

H. Zhai. “Presidential Elections and Cryptocurrency Returns: Evidence from 2020 and 2024.”

C. Wang and H. Zhai. “A New Bayesian Structural Scaling Approach to Party Position and Issue Salience.”

H. Zhai. “A Theory-Based Optimization Method for Measuring Intraparty Unity in Coalition Bargaining.”

E. Dinas, K. Northmore-Ball, and H. Zhai. “Between Ignoring and Remembering: Political Polarization and National Identity in Light of the Communist Past in Poland.”

Y. Wu and H. Zhai. “Housing Policy and Urban Life Satisfaction in China.”

CONFERENCE ACTIVITY

2024	C. Paik and H. Zhai. “The Mongol Conquest and Development in Eurasia before the Age of Exploration.” LEGACIES Workshop on Historical Institutions and Legacies, NTNU, Norway. Nov 18–19.
2023	H. Zhai. “Estimating Party Unity Scores with Formal Support: A New Gamson–Cox Approach.” APSA Annual Meeting & Exhibition, Los Angeles. Aug 31–Sep 3. Invited Talks
2021	“An Introduction to the COVID-19 Model Challenges.” CIVICA Research Hackathon, LSE Data Science Institute. Oct 21.

GRANTS, FELLOWSHIPS & AWARDS

2024	LEGACIES Workshop Travel Grant (ERC project funding)
2023	Warren E. Miller Scholarship, ICPSR Summer Program in Quantitative Methods
2023	Empirical Implications of Theoretical Models Summer Institute Scholarship (NSF grant)
2022–2023	European University Institute Graduate Research Expenses (×2)
2022–2023	Society for Political Methodology Conference Travel Grants (×2)
2021	EITM Certification Scholarship, ICPSR Summer Program in Quantitative Methods
2020	Berkeley Initiative for Transparency in the Social Sciences Scholarship
2019–2023	Italian Ministry of Foreign Affairs Ph.D. Studentship
2019	University of Oxford, St Catherine’s College Graduate Research Fund
2017	UK Data Service Dissertation Prize (Best Undergraduate Research Using Quantitative Research Methods)
2016	Bristol Evelyn Miller-Barstow Prize (Exceptional Academic Performance in Undergraduate Study)
2016	University of Bristol Q-Step Internship Scheme
2014	University of Bristol SPAIS International Scholarship

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

2026	Website and submission–system support, RC28 (ISA Research Committee on Social Stratification and Mobility) Conference, New York University Abu Dhabi
2025–2026	Editorial and design support, newsletter of the APSA Comparative Politics Section

QUANTITATIVE & ECONOMICS COURSEWORK

Completed for credit or audited at the host institution.

2026	Advanced Macroeconomics (undergraduate), New York University Abu Dhabi
2025	Topics in Financial Econometrics (undergraduate), New York University Abu Dhabi
2025	Econometrics (graduate), New York University Abu Dhabi
2024	Mathematical Statistics and Probability (graduate), New York University Abu Dhabi
2024	Game Theory (graduate), New York University Abu Dhabi
2024	Mathematics II (graduate), New York University Abu Dhabi
2023	EITM Summer Institute (Empirical Implications of Theoretical Models)
2023	ICPSR Summer Program in Quantitative Methods, University of Michigan
2021	Statistical Machine Learning (graduate), Bocconi University
2021	Numerical Methods for Economists (graduate), Sciences Po
2021	ICPSR Summer Program in Quantitative Methods, University of Michigan
2020	Statistics and Econometrics I–II (graduate), European University Institute

TECHNICAL SKILLS & LANGUAGES

Programming & Data Analysis: R, Python, Julia, GIS, High-Performance Computing (HPC)

Quantitative Methods: Econometrics, causal inference, game theory, applied Bayesian models, survey and field experiments, meta-analysis, spatial analysis, statistical machine learning

Research Tools: LaTeX, Git, Markdown, R Markdown, Microsoft Office, Adobe InDesign

Languages: English (fluent), Chinese (native), Italian and German (basic)